121,077

No. of adults from urban and rural areas of 36 states, Union Territories and the National Capital Territory-Delhi who were analysed for the study



CARB OVERLOAD

- Share of carbohydrate Indians consume is highest in the world
- Nearly two-thirds of daily energy comes from carbs alone
- Primary sources remain white rice, refined wheat flour and polished grains

THE OUTCOMES

These affordable and culturally central staples, when eaten in excess, raise metabolic risk. Higher carb intake is linked to:

- Increased diabetes risk
- Higher overall obesity
- Greater central (belly) fat accumulation

THE FAT IMBALANCE

- Saturated fat consumption is high (less than 7% of daily energy) in all but four states
- Intake of protective fats remains limited
- As diets modernise, fat intake has increased, but its quality has not kept pace. There's low intake of Omega-3 fatty acids and monounsaturated fats

THE OUTCOMES

Low intake of quality fat leads to increasing risk of insulin resistance and diabetes

THE PROTEIN GAP

- Most dietary protein comes from cereals and pulses, not complete sources
- Intake of high-quality protein remains low across regions and incomes
- There's low consumption of eggs, fish, dairy and meat

THE OUTCOMES

Low protein reduces satiety after meals. This encourages higher carb intake later in the day. Over time, this pattern worsens insulin resistance

SUGAR: THE SILENT EXCESS

- Added sugar intake exceeds limits in 21 of 36 states and UTs
- Recommended intake: <5% of daily energy
- Much of this sugar is consumed daily, not occasionally
- Common sources: sweetened tea/ coffee, traditional sweets and packaged foods

THE OUTCOMES

Added sugar provides calories without nutrition. It accelerates weight gain and insulin resistance

THE EFFECTIVE DIET FIX

WHAT DOESN'T WORK ALONE

- Switching from rice or wheat to milled millets
- Using whole-grain flour without reducing portion size
- Whole grains are healthier, but still carbohydrate-dense. Total carb load remains the key driver

WHAT WORKS

- Replacing at least 5% of calories from carbs with protein
- Health benefits seen with higher intake of plant protein, dairy, eggs and fish